

UNIVERSITY OF PERADENIYA

THE WONDER 7 OF PERADENIYA

A Journey Through the Architectural Marvels and Scenic
Wonders of Campus



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Introduction

Welcome to 'The Wonder 7 of Peradeniya'. The University of Peradeniya is widely celebrated as one of the most picturesque universities in the world. Blending breathtaking natural landscapes with stunning architectural landmarks, this document explores the seven wonders that define the unique identity and heritage of this esteemed institution.



Akbar Bridge

The Akbar Bridge is a renowned architectural and engineering landmark at the University of Peradeniya in Sri Lanka, spanning the Mahaweli River to connect the Faculty of Engineering with the main campus. Named in honor of Justice M.T. Akbar—who chaired the 1926 committee that recommended establishing a residential university outside Colombo—the bridge was designed by Professor A. Thurairajah, a distinguished former Dean of the Faculty of Engineering. It is celebrated as a masterpiece of local engineering, featuring a unique structural design that relies on the tensile strength of concrete.



Rather than being rigidly fixed, the bridge rests loosely on its supports, famously causing it to bounce or rock gently if individuals jump on it simultaneously. Set against the scenic backdrop of the river and lush surrounding flora, it serves both as an essential daily transit route for students and faculty and as a memorable symbol of the university's academic heritage.



Sarachchandra Open-Air Theatre



The **Sarachchandra Open-Air Theatre**, universally known as "**The Wala**" (meaning "the pit" or "hole" in Sinhala), is a legendary landmark nestled within the University of Peradeniya. Built in the early 1950s and designed after the architectural style of ancient Greek amphitheatres, it is officially named in memory of Professor Ediriweera Sarachchandra, Sri Lanka's iconic playwright who revolutionized local theatre with masterpieces like *Maname* and *Sinhabahu*. Characterized by its sunken, bowl-like layout, The Wala serves as the vibrant cultural heart of the campus, hosting historic drama premieres, musical concerts, student gatherings, and vibrant festivals that have deeply shaped Sri Lanka's artistic and university heritage for decades.



Senate Building



The **Senate Building** at the University of Peradeniya is a striking architectural landmark that serves as the central administrative hub of the institution. Designed by veteran architect Shirley de Alwis, the building is famously raised on numerous granite pillars—an inspired structural concept drawn from ancient Sri Lankan architecture,

specifically resembling the historic *Lova Maha Paya* (The Brazen Palace) of Anuradhapura. Located near the Faculty of Arts premises and adjacent to the university's massive main library, it houses key administrative offices, including the chambers of the Vice-Chancellor and academic council meeting rooms. Highlighted by traditional stone carvings, a distinct moonstone at its entrance, and a picturesque environment framed by vibrant yellow-flowering trees that bloom every April, the Senate Building stands as a majestic symbol of the university's rich heritage and colonial-era design.



Engineering Faculty Portico



The Engineering Faculty Portico at the University of Peradeniya is a magnificent and iconic architectural entrance that welcomes students and visitors to one of the most prestigious engineering faculties in the region. Designed during the university's early development in the mid-20th century, the portico

harmoniously blends modernist structural elements with classic academic grandeur, serving as the formal gateway to the faculty grounds. Characterized by its soaring concrete columns, sweeping architectural lines, and open-air design, it provides a dramatic frame against the lush, green backdrop of the Peradeniya campus. Beyond its aesthetic appeal, the portico acts as a vital daily meeting point and communal hub for engineering students, deeply intertwined with the identity, traditions, and vibrant student life of the faculty.



Main Library

The **Main Library** of the University of Peradeniya is an architectural masterpiece and one of the largest and most prestigious academic libraries in Sri Lanka. Situated near the Senate Building, it commands a picturesque view overlooking the Mahaweli River and the surrounding hill country. The library boasts an extensive collection of hundreds of thousands of volumes, rare manuscripts, and historical archives, serving as an essential intellectual sanctuary for generations of students and researchers. Blending classic mid-20th-century design with functional academic spaces, it stands not only as the academic heart of the university but also as a historic monument dedicated to the pursuit of knowledge and scholarly excellence.



Charcoal/Cinder Running Track



The **Charcoal Running-Track** (often referred to as part of the university's traditional athletic grounds) is a unique and historic sporting feature of the University of Peradeniya. Popularly celebrated in campus lore as one of its distinct features, the track is uniquely layered with crushed charcoal beneath its surface, a design choice meant to assist with drainage and shock absorption amidst the heavy rainfall typical of the hill country. Set against the scenic, lush green backdrop of the campus grounds, this traditional running track has served for decades as a training ground for generations of Peradeniya athletes, hosting inter-faculty tournaments, annual sports meets, and contributing to the vibrant athletic culture of the university.



The Mahaweli Floodplain /Gal Palama (Stone Bridge)

The Mahaweli River surrounding the University of Peradeniya is famously punctuated by historic crossings, most notably the scenic **Peradeniya Suspension Bridge** (often locally associated with the area's historic pathways or referred to historically alongside nearby landmarks like the old satinwood and stone-linked routes). While the campus itself features the renowned Akbar Bridge, the wider Peradeniya area is globally tied to landmarks like the historic *Sangili Palama* (Hanging Bridge) built across the mighty Mahaweli River. This iconic pedestrian suspension bridge, characterized by its towering steel pylons and wooden plank deck, is celebrated for the thrilling, rhythmic sway it produces with every step. Set against a breathtaking backdrop of lush tropical foliage, flowing river waters, and deep academic and royal history, these riverside bridges serve as timeless atmospheric symbols of the region's unique heritage.



